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URL of this page: https://medlineplus.gov/dietaryfats.html

Dietary Fats

Also called: Lipids, Monounsaturated fat, Polyunsaturated fat, Saturated fat

Fat is a type of nutrient. You need some fat in your diet but not too much. Fats give you energy and help your body absorb vitamins. Dietary fat also plays a major role in your cholesterol levels [https://medlineplus.gov/cholesterollevelswhatyouneedtoknow.html] .

But not all fats are the same. You should try to avoid:

- Saturated fats such as butter, solid shortening, and lard
- Trans fats. These are found in vegetable shortenings, some margarines, crackers, cookies, snack foods, and other foods made with or fried in partially hydrogenated oils (PHOs). By 2018, most U.S. companies will not be allowed to add PHOs to food.

Try to replace them with oils such as canola, olive, safflower, sesame, or sunflower. Of course, eating too much fat will put on the pounds. Fat has twice as many calories as proteins or carbohydrates.

NIH: National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute

Start Here

- How to Track Saturated Fat [https://www.mayoclinic.org/healthy-lifestyle/nutrition-and-healthy-eating/expert-answers/fat-grams/faq-20058496?p=1]
  (Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.mayoclinic.org/es/healthy-lifestyle/nutrition-and-healthy-eating/expert-answers/fat-grams/faq-20058496?p=1]
- The Skinny on Fat: The Good, the Bad, and the Unknown [https://newsinhealth.nih.gov/2019/07/skinny-fat] (National Institutes of Health)
  Also in Spanish [https://salud.nih.gov/recursos-de-salud/nih-noticias-de-salud/lo-delgado-sobre-la-grasa]
- The Skinny on Fats [https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/cholesterol/prevention-and-treatment-of-high-cholesterol-hyperlipidemia/the-skinny-on-fats] (American Heart Association)

- What Do Fats Do in the Body? [https://nigms.nih.gov/biobeat/2024/01/what-do-fats-do-in-the-body] (National Institute of General Medical Sciences)

Specifics

- 7 Things to Know about Omega-3 Fatty Acids [https://www.nccih.nih.gov/health/tips/things-to-know-about-omega-fatty-acids] (National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health)
- Butter vs. Margarine: Which Is Better for My Heart? [https://www.mayoclinic.org/healthy-lifestyle/nutrition-and-healthy-eating/expert-answers/butter-vs-margarine/faq-20058152?p=1] (Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.mayoclinic.org/es/healthy-lifestyle/nutrition-and-healthy-eating/expert-answers/butter-vs-margarine/faq-20058152?p=1]
- Eat Healthy: More Key Topics (Oils, Sugars, Saturated Fat, Sodium, Alcohol) [https://www.myplate.gov/eat-healthy/more-key-topics] (Department of Agriculture)
- Healthy Recipes: Low-fat [https://medlineplus.gov/recipes/low-fat/] (National Library of Medicine)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/recetas/bajo-en-grasa/]
- Omega-3 Supplements: What You Need to Know [https://www.nccih.nih.gov/health/omega3-supplements-what-you-need-to-know] (National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health)
- What Are Chia Seeds? [https://www.eatright.org/food/food-groups/fats/what-are-chia-seeds] (Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics)

Clinical Trials

- ClinicalTrials.gov: Dietary Fats [https://clinicaltrials.gov/search?term=%22dietary+fats%22&aggFilters=status:not%20rec] (National Institutes of Health)
- ClinicalTrials.gov: Fatty Acids [https://clinicaltrials.gov/search?intr=%22Fatty+Acids%22&aggFilters=status:not%20rec] (National Institutes of Health)
- ClinicalTrials.gov: Fatty Acids, Omega-3 [https://clinicaltrials.gov/search?intr=%22Fatty+Acids,+Omega-3%22&aggFilters=status:not%20rec] (National Institutes of Health)

Journal Articles

References and abstracts from MEDLINE/PubMed (National Library of Medicine)

- Article: The Impact of a Fat-Dominant Preload Before a Carbohydrate-Rich Meal on... [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41683291]
- Article: Duration of Type 2 Diabetes Mellitus Alters Orosensory Detection of Sweet... [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41683254]
- Article: Psychometric Properties of the Turkish Version of the Dietary Fat and... [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41683244]
- Dietary Fats -- see more articles [https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/?

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Find an Expert

- American Heart Association [https://www.heart.org/en/]
- Food and Drug Administration [https://www.fda.gov/]
- Food and Nutrition Information Center [https://www.nal.usda.gov/programs/fnic]
- National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute [https://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/]

Children

- Fats (for parents) [https://kidshealth.org/en/parents/fat.html] (Nemours Foundation)
  Also in Spanish [https://kidshealth.org/es/parents/fat.html]
- Learning about Fats [https://kidshealth.org/en/kids/fat.html] (Nemours Foundation)
  Also in Spanish [https://kidshealth.org/es/kids/fat.html]

Teenagers

- Dietary Fat and Cholesterol [https://youngwomenshealth.org/guides/dietary-fat-and-cholesterol/] (Boston Children's Hospital)
  Also in Spanish [https://youngwomenshealth.org/guias/el-colesterol-y-las-grasas/]
- Figuring Out Fat and Calories [https://kidshealth.org/en/teens/fat-calories.html] (Nemours Foundation)
  Also in Spanish [https://kidshealth.org/es/teens/fat-calories.html]

Patient Handouts

- Butter, margarine, and cooking oils [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000095.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000095.htm]
- Dietary fats explained [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000104.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000104.htm]
- Facts about monounsaturated fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000785.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000785.htm]
- Facts about polyunsaturated fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000747.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000747.htm]
- Facts about saturated fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000838.htm]

(Medical Encyclopedia)
Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000838.htm]

- Facts about trans fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000786.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000786.htm]
- Omega-3 fats - Good for your heart [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000767.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000767.htm]

MEDICAL ENCYCLOPEDIA

Butter, margarine, and cooking oils [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000095.htm]

Dietary fats explained [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000104.htm]

Facts about monounsaturated fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000785.htm]

Facts about polyunsaturated fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000747.htm]

Facts about saturated fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000838.htm]

Facts about trans fats [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000786.htm]

Omega-3 fats - Good for your heart [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000767.htm]

Related Health Topics

Cholesterol [https://medlineplus.gov/cholesterol.html]

How to Prevent Heart Disease [https://medlineplus.gov/howtopreventheartdisease.html]

Lipid Metabolism Disorders [https://medlineplus.gov/lipidmetabolismdisorders.html]

Nutrition [https://medlineplus.gov/nutrition.html]

Triglycerides [https://medlineplus.gov/triglycerides.html]

National Institutes of Health

The primary NIH organization for research on *Dietary Fats* is the National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute [http://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/]

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